# Amtrak Rail Pass

This summer, I plan to use the Amtrak Rail Pass to travel for 1 month. This blog will contain my plans for the journey, and my thoughts on each day's experiences.
The following map gives an overview of the approximate Amtrak routes across the U.S. Chicago is the center of the rail network.

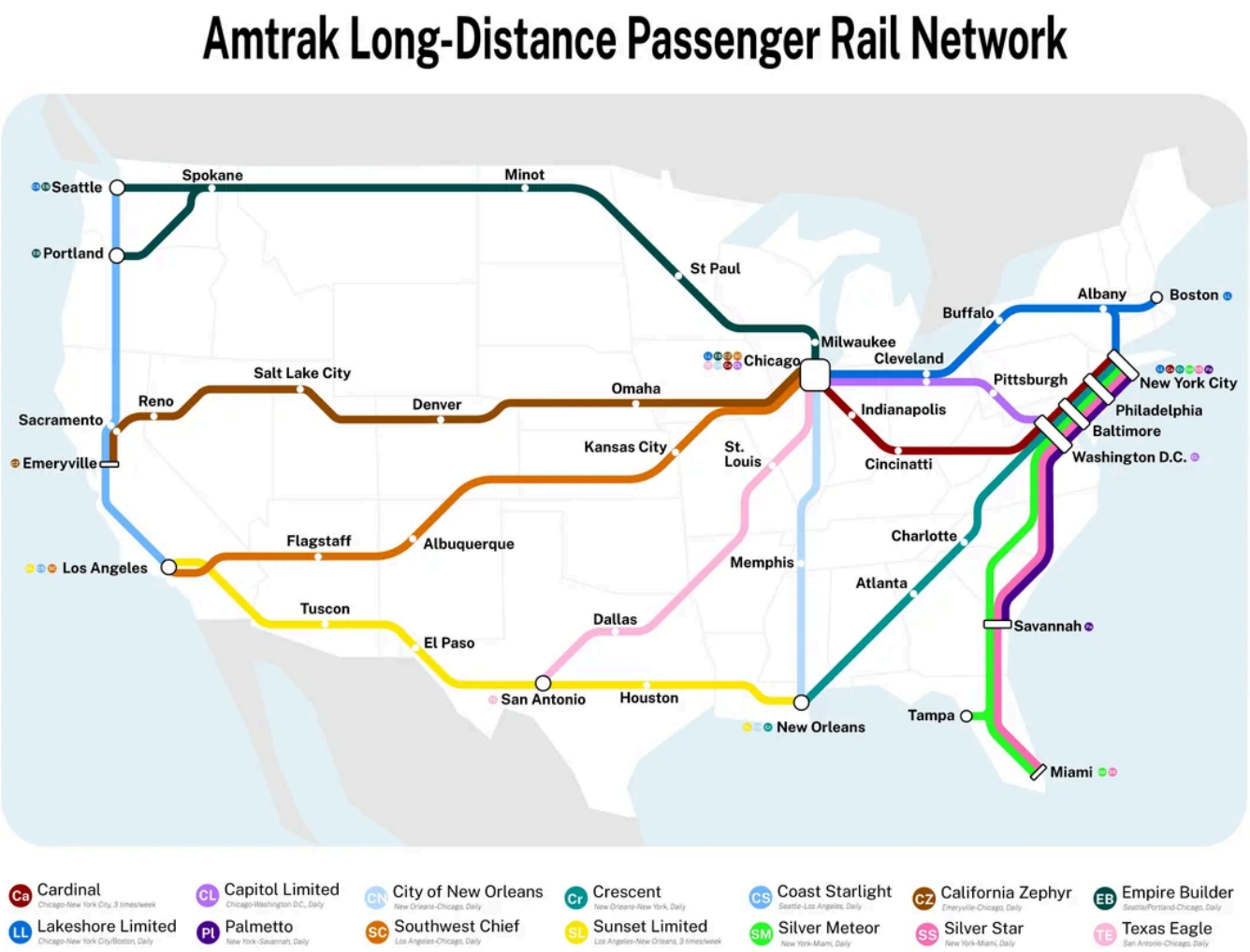


Figure 1: Amtrak Route Map [1]

## Itinerary

Currently, the itinerary of cities is

- Marshall, Texas -> Chicago (Texas Eagle) April 25-26
- Chicago -> Boston (Lakeshore Limited) April 26-27
- Boston -> New York City (Lakeshore Limited) April 30
- New York City -> Philadelphia (Vermonter) May 5
- Philadelpha -> Washington D.C. (Northeast Regional) May 8
- Washington D.C. -> Chicago (Floridian) May 11th-May 12
- Chicago -> Seattle (Empire Builder) May 12-May 14
- Seattle -> Emeryville (Coast Starlight) May 17-May 18
- Emeryville -> Chicago (California Zephyr) May 20-22
- Chicago -> Dallas (Texas Eagle) May 23-May 24

## Boston - April 27th-30th

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Day 1 — Apr 28** | 9:00 AM | Boston Common | FREE | Start here |

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Morning | Public Garden | FREE | Swan Boats seasonal |
| | Morning | Beacon Hill Friends House | FREE | Brief stop |
| | Mid-Morning | Freedom Trail (2.5 mi) | FREE | Follow red brick path |
| | Mid-Morning | Park Street Church | FREE | Along trail |
| | Mid-Morning | Granary Burying Ground | FREE | Along trail |
| | Mid-Morning | King’s Chapel | FREE | Along trail |
| | Lunch | Faneuil Hall & Quincy Market | FREE | Browse & eat |
| | Afternoon | Paul Revere House | $5.50 | |
| | Afternoon | Old North Church | $5 | |
| | Lunch/Dinner | Galleria Umberto | $8–$12 | Cash only |
| | Evening | Rose Kennedy Greenway | FREE | Neighborhood stroll |
| | Evening | Beacon Hill | FREE | End near South Station |
| **Day 2 – Apr 29** | Morning | Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum | $15 | 2–3 hours |
| | Midday | Museum of Fine Arts | $30 | |
| | Afternoon | Trinity Church | FREE | Back Bay, 30 min |
| | Afternoon | Boston Public Library | FREE | Back Bay, 30 min |
| | Afternoon | Copley Square | FREE | Walk around |
| **Day 3 – Apr 30** | Morning | Newbury Street | FREE | Shopping/dining |
| | Morning | Harvard Square | FREE | If not done Day 2 |
| | Midday | Waterfront/Harbor Walk | FREE | Scenic walk |
| | Midday | Seaport District | FREE | Restaurants & browsing |
| | **7:47 PM** | **Depart South Station** | – | – |

## New York City - April 30th-May 5th

- Museum Mile free/cheap student picks: The Met (pay-what-you-wish, can pay $1 with ID), El Museo del Barrio (free), Museum of the City of New York (free) — skip the Neue Galerie ($25, no discount)

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Apr 30** | 11:49 PM | Arrive Queens | – | Check in, rest |
| **Day 1 – May 1 (Manhattan)** | Morning | Times Square | FREE | Less crowded early |
| | Morning | New York Public Library | FREE | |
| | Mid-Morning | Grand Central Station | FREE | |
| | Mid-Morning | Rockefeller Center | FREE | Exterior |
| | Afternoon | AMNH | Pay-what-you-wish | Can pay $1 w/ student ID |
| | Afternoon | Central Park | FREE | Walk through after AMNH |
| | Evening | Greenwich Village | FREE | Dinner & wander |
| **Day 2 – May 2 (Manhattan)** | Morning | 5th Avenue + St. Patrick’s Cathedral | FREE | Start midtown, walk north |

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Mid-Morning | Museum Mile (82nd–105th St) | – | All on 5th Ave |
| | Mid-Morning | The Met | Pay-what-you-wish | Can pay $1 w/ student ID |
| | Mid-Morning | El Museo del Barrio | **FREE** | Students free |
| | Mid-Morning | Museum of the City of New York | **FREE** | Students free |
| | Afternoon | Guggenheim | **$18** | Student ID |
| | Evening ⭐ | MoMA | **FREE** | Free every Fri 5:30–9pm |
| **Day 3 – May 3 (Queens)** | Morning | Flushing Chinatown | FREE | Best cheap food in NYC |
| | Afternoon | Flushing Meadows-Corona Park | FREE | USTA, Queens Museum nearby |
| | Evening | Jackson Heights | FREE | Little India – great cheap eats |
| **Day 4 – May 4 (Brooklyn)** | Morning | Brooklyn Botanic Garden | ~$15 | Free Tues & select Sat mornings |
| | Midday | Prospect Park | FREE | Adjacent to BBG |
| | Afternoon | DUMBO | FREE | Great Manhattan Bridge views |
| | Afternoon | Walk Brooklyn Bridge | FREE | Brooklyn→Manhattan side |
| | Evening | Little Italy | FREE | Dinner on the way back |
| **Day 5 – May 5 (Queens AM)** | Morning | Explore local Queens neighborhood | FREE | Easy since you're staying there |
| | Mid-Morning | Statue of Liberty – Battery Park or Staten Island Ferry | FREE | Ferry is free + closer views |
| | Afternoon | The Edge / Penn Station area | ~$38 or FREE | Optional last splurge before departure |
| | **6:49 PM** | **Depart NYC** | – | |

## Philadelphia - May 5th-May 8th

Figure 2: Map of Philadelphia's Murals

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **May 5** | 8:07 PM | Arrive Philadelphia | — | Grab food near hotel; Reading Terminal closes ~6pm |
| **Day 1 — May 6 (Old City)** | Morning | Liberty Bell | **FREE** | NPS; no tickets needed |
| | Morning | Independence Hall | **FREE** | Free timed-entry — book at recreation.gov in advance |
| | Mid-Morning | Free Quaker Meeting House | **FREE** | Steps from Independence Hall |
| | Mid-Morning | Arch Street Meeting House | Free/donation | Oldest continuously used meetinghouse in the US |
| | Mid-Morning | Elfreth’s Alley | **FREE** | Oldest residential street in the US; very photogenic |
| | Midday | Reading Terminal Market | FREE to enter | Lunch; $8–15 for a full meal |
| | Afternoon | Delaware River Waterfront | **FREE** | Penn’s Landing, scenic walk |
| | Evening | Old City murals / wander | **FREE** | Philly has some of the best street art in the US |
| **Day 2 — May 7 (South Philly + Center City)** | Morning | Italian Market | **FREE** | Oldest open-air market in the US; great cheap eats |
| | Mid-Morning | Magic Gardens | **~$10** | Student discount; Isaiah Zagar mosaic art on South Street |
| | Midday | South Street | **FREE** | Wander, lunch, shops |
| | Afternoon | Rittenhouse Square | **FREE** | Beautiful park, upscale neighborhood |
| | Afternoon | City Hall | **FREE** | Walk around; observation tower ~$8 |
| | Evening | Fishtown | **FREE** | Hip neighborhood, great cheap dinner spots |
| **Day 3 — May 8 (Parkway Morning)** | Morning | Benjamin Franklin Parkway | **FREE** | Outdoor scenic boulevard |
| | Mid-Morning | Philadelphia Museum of Art | **~$14** | Student ID; Rocky steps are always free |
| | **1:47 PM** | **Depart Philadelphia** | — | |

## Washington D.C. - May 8th-May 11th

- Smithsonian Museums
- Baltimore

## Seattle - May 14-May 17

## San Francisco - May 18-May 20

## Packing List

### Essentials

- ☑ Hiking Bag
- ☑ Water Bottle
- ☑ Sleeping Bag
- ☐ Trackers
- ☐ Day Bag

### Clothing

### Essentials

- ☐ 3 Pants
- ☐ 1 Sweatpant
- ☐ 2 Undershirt
- ☐ 3 Athletic T-Shirts
- ☐ 1 Sweater
- ☐ 4 Socks
- ☐ 4 Underwear
- ☐ Shoes
- ☑ Windbreaker

### Extra

- ☑ Emergency Poncho
- ☑ Umbrella
- ☑ Needle/Thread

### Toiletries

- ☐ Towel
- ☐ Toothbrush/toothpaste
- ☐ Mouth Guard
- ☑ Deodorant
- ☐ Shampoo/soap (travel sizes)
- ☐ Hand sanitizer
- ☑ First Aid Kit
- ☑ Sunscreen
- ☐ TP
- ☑ First Aid Kit

### Electronics

- ☐ Phone/Charger
- ☐ Laptop/Charger
- ☐ Battery Pack

### Food

### Grocery Items

- ☐ Granola
- ☐ Dried Fruit
- ☐ Bread
- ☐ Hard Cheese
- ☐ Nut Butter
- ☐ Dark Chocolate

### Extra

- ☐ Spoon/Knife/Fork

### Other

- ☑ Playing Cards
- ☐ Ziploc Bag
- ☐ Driver's License
- ☐ Pictures of Passport
- ☐ Credit/Debit Card
- ☐ Printed Tickets

# Bibliography

[1] caliberal, "A map I made showing the Amtrak long-distance routes." 2023.